“Hey Jeuwo” a whisper from across the boat.

“Zhuozin, is that you?” I whispered.

“Yeah,” Zhuozin crept across the ship’s deck to come sit by my side by the sail.

The ship groaned softly against the wooden dock. It’s ropes stretched and rested in rhythm of the waves. The dim moonlight was at the horizon, lighting up the subtle waves out from the dock. The sky was littered with white and yellow dots and colourful shifting shapes. The town’s lanterns flickered as if they captured the stars.

“Couldn’t get to sleep either?” I said gazing at the night sky.

“Nah, that’s not why you’re out this late and you know it.” Zhuozin bantered.

“Do I?” I giggled.

“You were talking so much yesterday on the skies being clear, and I know about ya.”

“And you’re out here to see the stars too?” I relaxed

“I’m here to see you.” Zhuozin said tenderly.

“They tease me for how many night watches you volunteer to spend with me.” I said. Zhuozin smirked and leaned closer.

A gentle and cold breeze blew over the sails.

“What shape are the nebulae tonight?” I asked.

“They’re pretty and all, but something else is colourful an pretty on this boat and I ain’t talking about the captain.” they responded.

“Laureau’s got quite the style, I think”

“Suppose she does, but it don’t resemble the nebulae.”

“Yeah, she’s more like a star, glistening in the sky with a burning passion.” I proclaimed.

Their gaze drifted upwards.

“You got a telescope, Jeuwo?” Zhuozin asked.

“No, why?”

“We’re lookin at the stars ain’t we?”

“I’m certain the captain keeps hers in her bedchambers.” I sighed.

Zhuozin gave me an encouraging look. I grinned.

“You can’t be suggesting we break into her chamber and pilfer her prized possessions as she sleeps?” I smirked.

“You wanna see the stars, dont cha?”

“I’m sure she wouldn’t mind”

“And would appreciate not bein’ woken up!”

We stood and crept to the back of the ship. The captain’s bedroom was through the ‘common hall’ as she called it. A fine room we would spend our smoothly sailed days, with comfortable seats and a wall lined with books. The moonlight reflected through the windows.

The captain's bedchamber door was locked, but not enchanted. Zhuozin whipped out a skeleton key, as if they had this planned all along. The captain's quarters were not luxurious or spacious, as they were on many other's ships. Laureau spent some time in Ereso and chose that she should be living in no more luxury than her own privacy. She slept soundly on a small bed, telescope half an arm's length from her face.

Zhuozin skillfully grabbed hold of the telescope, but in lifting it they whacked it against a candlestick sounding a musical ring.

Laureau ruffled in her bed. Zhuozin and I carefully backed out.

"You should just…" Laureau muffled in her slumber, "kiss him already…" Her tone a sleepy banter.

Zhuozin and I froze. She tossed in her bed before falling back asleep.

Zhuozin made sure to lock her door on the way out.

"We ought'a climb the sails and get a better view of the sky."

"Let's"

Zhuozin ran up the rigging, gripping the knots like a dextrous wall climber. I, timidly, put one hand in front of the other going up the rope ladder that Laureau put in place for the specific purpose of having us climb the rigging less. Zhuozin was waiting for me at the highest crosstree.

"Here ya go!" They handed me the telescope.

I extended it and pointed it towards the sky. I peered through it.

"What do ya see?"

I adjusted the lens' focus.

"The stars are still dots of light. But look there, " I pressed against Zhuozin and pointed towards a nebula in the sky "The nebulae glisten with colour on a closer look. It had a peace and fury to it. You should see for yourself." I passed the telescope to them.

I stared at the sky longer. Even without the telescope I started to notice the rainbows of the nebulae.

"I can see something beautiful all right!"

Zhuozin was pointing the telescope right at me. I smiled.

"That face is brighter than any of them stars, Jeuwo."

"You climbed the ropes with so much courage during the last storm. I see your vigour in the way you argue with the captain's routes to take. Neither the stars nor the nebulae match your fire."

"Aw, Jeuwo, you can't say that about me!"

"The scholars, they all say it's some magical phenomena, half the stars and all the nebulae. The other half of the stars are just like the sun but so far away they look so small."

"Really?"

"I read it in a book. I'll never know if it's true, magic in the sky, but I know there's magic right here. On the boat, on this mast."

"Now, i's heard it ain't really magic no more, we got sciences on this stuff."

"That's not what I'm talking about, Zhuozin"

"An' I know it."

Zhuozin wrapped their hands around mine. Their Iris was a peaceful and furious nebula. Their pupil reflected the stars behind me.

“I love you, Jeuwo.” They whispered

“I think Laureau was right.”

And then we snogged all night and I grabbed his hair and almost fell off the mast, but I held on :-)